

National Gallery - Kids

UK Family Tour

Sunflowers and a Giant Horse

Two paintings to hunt for first. Number one: Vincent van Gogh's Sunflowers, one of the most famous paintings on Earth. Van Gogh painted it in 1888 to decorate a bedroom for his friend, the painter Gauguin, who was coming to stay. He painted sunflowers because he loved yellow — he believed yellow meant happiness and friendship — and he worked fast, because cut sunflowers droop within days. Look closely: the paint is so thick in places it stands up off the canvas like frosting. In his whole life, Van Gogh barely sold any paintings; today this one is worth more money than you could spend in a hundred lifetimes. Number two: find Whistlejacket — you can't miss him. He's a life-sized rearing horse, nearly three meters tall, painted by George Stubbs around 1762, with nothing else in the picture. No rider, no field, no sky. Just horse. Whistlejacket was a real, famous, extremely grumpy racehorse. There's a legend that when the horse saw the finished painting, he thought it was a rival stallion and tried to attack it. Stubbs knew horses inside out — literally. He spent eighteen months dissecting horses and drawing every muscle, so his horses look more real than anyone else's ever had.

Tell Me More: Van Gogh and Stubbs

More on both artists. Van Gogh painted seven Sunflowers pictures in total, and the paintings have adventures of their own: one was destroyed in Japan during World War Two, and the others live in museums around the world — London's is one of the most loved. Vincent's brother Theo supported him his whole life, sending money and paints; Vincent wrote him over six hundred letters, which is how we know so much about what he thought — including that he ate paint-stained bread by accident and worked so fast in the southern heat that flies got stuck in the wet paint. Look closely: conservators have found insects embedded in some Van Goghs. He signed this painting "Vincent," just his first name, because nobody outside Holland could pronounce "Van Gogh" — and honestly, most people still say it wrong. As for Stubbs and Whistlejacket: the horse was a champion racer owned by one of the richest men in England, and Stubbs earned his skills the hard way — before photography, the only way to truly know animal anatomy was dissection, so he spent a year and a half in a remote farmhouse studying horse anatomy layer by layer, publishing a famous book of drawings that veterinarians used for a century. The blank background wasn't laziness: it may have been meant for another artist to add a king riding him — but the horse alone looked so powerful that everyone agreed: don't touch it.

The Empty Chair and the Broken Friendship

Here is a sadder story hiding in this same gallery. When Van Gogh painted those Sunflowers, he was getting a little yellow house in the south of France ready, because his friend Gauguin was coming to live and paint with him. Van Gogh dreamed they would start an artists' family together. But once Gauguin arrived, the two men argued about almost everything, day after day, until it all fell apart. On one terrible night Van Gogh became so upset that he cut off part of his own ear. Gauguin packed up and left, and the dream was over.

Now look for another Van Gogh in this building, a painting simply called Van Gogh's Chair. It is a plain wooden chair with his pipe and tobacco resting on the seat, and nobody sitting in it. Van Gogh painted it as a kind of portrait of himself without a face, just his empty chair. He painted a second, fancier chair for Gauguin too. Two chairs, two very different men, one friendship that broke.

So when you stand in front of the glowing Sunflowers, remember that the same hand painted that lonely little chair. Van Gogh made some of the happiest, brightest paintings in the whole world during some of the saddest days of his life. He kept painting almost to the very end, and he never knew that one day millions of people would travel across the planet just to stand where you are standing and look at his flowers.

Whistlejacket's Racing World

Stand back and take in how enormous Whistlejacket really is. The canvas is almost three meters tall, so the horse is close to life sized, looming right over you. Most paintings this big were saved for kings or famous battles, so painting one single horse this large was a bold, almost cheeky thing to do.

The real Whistlejacket belonged to one of the richest men in England, the Marquess of Rockingham, who owned a country estate with its own racecourse and even served twice as Britain's Prime Minister. Whistlejacket was a champion, a chestnut racehorse famous for his fiery temper. The story goes that he was so wild he could barely be held still long enough to be painted, which makes his frozen, rearing pose feel even more alive.

George Stubbs was the perfect painter for him, because Stubbs understood horses better than any artist ever had. He didn't only paint them, he studied them from the inside out, spending a year and a half taking dead horses apart, muscle by muscle, to learn exactly how a horse is built. That is why his horses look like they could breathe and gallop right off the wall.

Stubbs loved painting powerful animals in dramatic moments. Elsewhere he painted a series showing a lion creeping up on a terrified horse, all bared teeth and rolling eyes. So look again at Whistlejacket, alone against that blank golden background, with no field and no sky, and ask yourself what he is reacting to. There is nothing there. Stubbs leaves the danger up to your imagination.

The Hidden Skull and the Mirror Trick

Now for two paintings with secrets. First, find *The Ambassadors* by Hans Holbein, painted in 1533. Two rich young men stand surrounded by their expensive stuff — globes, instruments, a lute. But look at the strange grey smear stretched across the floor between them. Now walk to the right side of the painting, get close to the wall, and look back at the smear at a sharp angle. It snaps into shape: a perfect human skull. It's called anamorphosis — a stretched image that only looks right from one exact spot. Painters used skulls as a reminder that life is short, but Holbein turned his into a magic trick that still works after five hundred years. Second: *The Arnolfini Portrait* by Jan van Eyck, from 1434 — a man and woman in a fancy room, holding hands. Find the small round mirror on the back wall and look as closely as the guards allow. Reflected in it, you can see the backs of the couple — and two tiny extra people standing where YOU are standing. One of them may be the painter himself, because above the mirror he wrote, in fancy script, “Jan van Eyck was here. 1434.” A six-hundred-year-old selfie, hidden in a mirror smaller than your palm.

Tell Me More: Painted Secrets Everywhere

Once you know paintings hide things, you can't stop finding them. In *The Ambassadors*, check the top left corner, half-hidden behind the green curtain: a tiny silver crucifix, peeking out — a quiet message that behind all the riches and gadgets, faith is watching. The lute on the shelf has a broken string, which in painting-language means harmony has snapped — these two men lived through Europe splitting apart over religion. Even the floor is a message: it copies the real medieval floor of Westminster Abbey, where kings are crowned. In the *Arnolfini Portrait*, count the details: one candle burns in the chandelier in broad daylight (a symbol, maybe of God's presence, maybe of a soul), the little dog means loyalty, the oranges on the windowsill were massively expensive imports showing off wealth, and the couple have taken their shoes off — you can spot the clogs — because the moment is sacred. Six hundred years ago, people could “read” a painting like you read a comic. One more trick to try today: find any portrait where the person seems to look straight at you — then walk slowly from one side of it to the other. The eyes will follow you. It works with any well-painted direct gaze, it's pure geometry, it has spooked people for centuries, and it never gets old.

How the Skull Trick Works

Let's figure out the secret behind that stretched grey smear in *The Ambassadors*. The trick is called anamorphosis, and painters have loved it for hundreds of years. Here is the idea. If you take a picture of a skull and squash and stretch it sideways in just the right way, it turns into an unrecognizable blur when you look at it straight on. But if you then stand off to one side and look along the surface of the painting at a sharp, sneaky angle, all that stretching cancels out, and the skull springs back into perfect shape.

Try it yourself, carefully, without bumping other visitors. Walk to the right edge of the painting, get low and close to the wall, and sight along the picture toward the smear. Watch it snap from a blur into a grinning skull. Then step back to the front, and watch it melt into nonsense again.

Experts think Holbein may have planned this painting to hang on a staircase, so that as people climbed the stairs and glanced sideways, the hidden skull would suddenly leap out at them, a spooky surprise as they walked past. Face on, you see two proud, wealthy young men and all their treasures. From the side, you see death quietly waiting. You cannot see both at once, and that is exactly the point Holbein wanted to make. Nearly five hundred years later, his clever trick still works on you today, using nothing but paint and geometry.

Two Ambassadors and a King's Big Argument

So who are these two serious young men in *The Ambassadors*, and why do they look so tense? They were real people, both visitors from France, sent to London on tricky business in the year 1533. And 1533 was one of the most dramatic years in English history.

That was the year King Henry the Eighth broke away from the Pope in Rome so he could divorce his first wife and marry a new one, Anne Boleyn. It split the whole country, and eventually all of Europe, into fierce arguments about religion, arguments that would lead to wars. These two ambassadors were caught right in the middle of it, trying to keep the peace between kings and popes. No wonder they look worried.

Holbein filled the space between them with clues about this troubled moment. Remember the lute with a snapped string. In the language of painting, a broken string meant harmony was breaking, exactly what was happening across Europe. There is a hymn book open to a song by Martin Luther, the monk who started the great religious quarrel. Even the two globes, one of the sky and one of the Earth, hint at a world being pulled in different directions.

Holbein himself worked for King Henry, painting the royal family and the powerful people at court. Painting kings was risky work, though. Later Holbein painted a princess so flatteringly that Henry agreed to marry her, then complained she looked nothing like her portrait in real life. In those days, a painter really could get in trouble for making someone look too good.

The Fighting Temeraire: A Hero's Last Trip

This painting once won a vote as Britain's favorite, and it's a picture of a goodbye. Find *The Fighting Temeraire* by J.M.W. Turner, painted in 1839. The tall, pale, ghostly sailing ship is the *Temeraire*, a hero of the Battle of Trafalgar in 1805 — the same battle as Nelson's column outside in the square. At Trafalgar she fought so bravely, rescuing Nelson's flagship and capturing two enemy ships, that she became famous across Britain. But by 1838 she was old, and the navy sold her for scrap. Turner shows her final journey: being towed up the Thames by a small, grubby, smoke-belching steam tugboat to be broken up for timber. Look at the trick Turner plays: the old ship is painted in silvery, ghostly colors, like she's already becoming a memory, while the little tug is dark and fiery — the new steam age dragging the old age of sail to its grave. Behind them, Turner paints a blazing sunset — the sun setting on the ship, and on a whole era. Turner loved this painting so much he called it “my darling” and refused every offer to sell it. If some of it looks familiar, this painting appears in a James Bond film, and it was on the British twenty-pound note along with Turner's face.

Tell Me More: Turner the Wild Man

Turner himself is worth a story. He was a barber's son from Covent Garden, a few streets from here, who became the most famous painter in Britain — and one of the strangest. He was short, gruff, secretive, traveled everywhere with a sketchbook, and claimed he once had sailors tie him to a ship's mast for four hours during a snowstorm so he could truly see what a storm at sea looked like, then went home and painted it. (Historians suspect he exaggerated. Turner didn't care.) On Varnishing Days — when artists could touch up paintings already hanging in the exhibition — Turner would arrive with an almost-blank canvas and paint the entire picture on the wall in front of an audience, showing off. Once, when a rival's painting next to his looked stronger, Turner walked up to his own seascape and added a single blob of red — a buoy — that made his painting snap into life and stole the show. The rival said: “Turner has been here and fired a gun.” When Turner died in 1851, he left hundreds of paintings and about nineteen thousand drawings and watercolors to the nation — one of the greatest gifts any artist has given a country. His last words were reported as “The sun is God.” Look at the sunset in the *Temeraire* and decide if you believe he said it.

The Real Ship and Her Last Battle

Turner's ghostly ship was a real ship, and she was a genuine hero. Her name was the *Temeraire*, and she was a mighty warship of the Royal Navy, a floating wooden fortress carrying ninety eight guns and hundreds of sailors.

Her greatest day came in 1805, at the Battle of Trafalgar, off the coast of Spain, where the British fleet led by Admiral Nelson fought the combined navies of France and Spain. In the thick of the smoke and cannon fire, the *Temeraire* fought so bravely that she rescued Nelson's own flagship, the *Victory*, which was being attacked from both sides. Then her crew captured two enemy ships at once, lashing them to her sides. After that day the whole country knew her name, and people began calling her the *Fighting Temeraire*.

But ships grow old, just like people. By 1838, more than thirty years after her moment of glory, she was worn out and no longer needed. The navy sold her to be taken apart for her valuable timber. And so, on a September evening, a small steam tugboat came to tow the great old warrior up the River Thames to a scrapyard, where she would be broken up piece by piece.

Turner may have watched it happen, or he may have only heard about it, but either way it moved him deeply, and he turned that quiet, sad little journey into one of the most famous paintings in Britain. Years

later she was voted the nation's favourite painting of all, and Turner and his ship even appeared together on the British twenty pound note.

The Painter Who Chased the Light

Look hard at the Temeraire's sky. That blazing, smoky, golden sunset is really the true subject of the painting. Turner cared more about light than almost anything else. He spent his whole life trying to catch the way sunlight glows through fog, bursts through storm clouds, or shimmers on water, things that are almost impossible to paint because they never hold still.

In his later years Turner grew bolder and bolder, until some of his paintings became swirling storms of colour where you can barely tell the sea from the sky. People at the time were puzzled. Some laughed and said his pictures looked like nothing at all, just smears of yellow and white. But Turner was ahead of his time. He had discovered that if you paint the light itself, rather than every tiny detail, you can make a painting feel more alive and more real than a photograph.

Here is the exciting part. A little while after Turner died, a young French painter named Claude Monet came to London, partly to escape a war back home. Monet saw Turner's glowing, misty pictures in this very city, and they amazed him. Soon Monet and his friends began painting light in their own new way, capturing sunshine and fog with quick, loose dabs of colour.

So Turner was like a door swinging open. On the other side of that door was a whole new kind of art called Impressionism, which you can go and find in another room of this same gallery. Keep Turner's blazing sunset in your mind, because you are about to see where his ideas led.

The Room Where Paintings Are Made of Light

Now walk into the Impressionist rooms, and get ready for paintings that break the rules. Find Claude Monet's Water-Lily Pond, with its pretty green Japanese bridge arching over a pond full of floating flowers. Now do something strange. Lean in close, almost too close, and look at the water. It is not painted smoothly at all. It is a wild jumble of quick dashes and blobs of green, blue, pink and purple, that up close looks like a lovely mess. Now step slowly backwards. Watch the mess turn into shimmering water and dancing sunlight. That is the Impressionist magic trick.

These painters, Monet and his friends Renoir, Degas, Pissarro and others, did something new about a hundred and fifty years ago. Instead of carefully painting every leaf and hair, they tried to catch the way light looks in a single passing moment, working fast with loose, feathery brushstrokes. They often carried their paints outdoors and painted right there in the sunshine.

When they first showed these paintings in Paris in 1874, people were shocked and even laughed. One grumpy critic looked at a Monet called Impression, Sunrise and sneered that it was just an impression, not a real finished painting. He meant it as an insult, but the painters liked the word so much they kept it, and called themselves the Impressionists.

Look around this room for Renoir's crowd of umbrellas on a rainy day, and see if you can spot a painting of an acrobat hanging by her teeth high up in a circus. These artists loved painting real, everyday, modern life.

Monet, the Man Who Painted the Same Thing Forever

Claude Monet had an idea that sounds a little bit crazy. He decided that the interesting thing to paint was not really the object in front of him, but the light falling on it, and light changes all the time. So Monet began painting the very same thing over and over and over again, at different times of day and in different weather.

He painted a row of haystacks in a field dozens of times, some glowing gold in morning light, some pink at sunset, some cold and blue in the snow. He painted the front of a great cathedral more than thirty times, watching the stone change colour as the sun moved across it. Same haystack, same cathedral, but completely different paintings, because the light was never the same twice.

To do this, Monet sometimes worked on several canvases at once, switching from one to the next as the light changed, then racing to finish each before that exact light disappeared. It was almost like trying to paint a rainbow before it fades.

His greatest subject of all was his own garden. Monet was so in love with light on water that he dug a pond, planted water lilies, and built that little green Japanese bridge, all just so he could paint them. He painted his water garden hundreds of times for the rest of his life. So when you look at the Water-Lily Pond here, you are looking at a spot Monet loved so much he built it with his own hands, purely so he could chase its light with his brush, again and again and again.

The Rebels Who Made Their Own Show

Here is how the Impressionists became famous, and it is really a story about brave rebels. Back then, if you were a painter in Paris, there was only one way to become successful. You had to get your paintings into a giant official exhibition called the Salon, chosen by a panel of strict, old fashioned judges. Those

judges liked smooth, polished paintings of history, myths and important people. They took one look at these new loose, sketchy, sunlit paintings and said no.

So in 1874, Monet and his friends did something daring. They refused to beg the judges any longer. They rented their own space and put on their very own exhibition, showing the world exactly the kind of art they believed in. It was a bold, risky thing to do, and at first many visitors laughed and the newspapers were cruel. But the painters kept going, holding show after show, until slowly people began to see the beauty in what they were doing.

Look closely at Renoir's painting of the umbrellas. If you study it carefully, you might notice that the people on one side look soft and feathery, while the people on the other side look a little crisper and sharper. That is because Renoir actually changed his style partway through and came back to finish it a few years later. It is like seeing an artist change his mind, frozen inside one painting.

And keep hunting for Degas, who loved painting ballet dancers stretching and resting, and circus performers, including that amazing acrobat spinning high in the air, hanging only by her teeth.

The Painting Made of Thousands of Dots

Get ready for the most amazing eye trick in the whole gallery. Find a huge painting called *Bathers at Asnières* by a young artist named Georges Seurat. It is enormous, about two meters tall and three meters wide, and it shows boys and men lazing by a river just outside Paris on a hot, hazy day. Everything is calm and still, as if time has stopped.

Now do the experiment. Walk right up close to the painting, as close as the guards allow, and stare at the grass or the water. You will see that it is not made of smooth colour at all. It is built from thousands and thousands of tiny separate dabs and dots of different colours sitting side by side. Little touches of blue right next to little touches of orange, green next to red, all mixed up like confetti.

Then slowly walk backwards, keeping your eyes on the painting. Watch the dots melt together. From far away, your own eyes blend all those separate specks into glowing, sunlit colour. Your eyes do the mixing, not the paint. It is a bit like how a screen makes pictures out of tiny coloured dots called pixels, except Seurat figured this out long before screens existed.

This careful, dotty way of painting later got the name pointillism, which just means made of points. Look nearby for a much smaller Seurat painting too, a little study of a rainbow. Seurat was young when he made these, and sadly he died when he was only thirty one, but his dazzling dot magic changed painting forever.

Why the Dots Turn Into Light

Let's understand the clever secret behind Seurat's dots. Here is the surprising part. If you want a patch of shimmering green grass, most painters would just mix blue and yellow paint together on their palette until they got green, then brush it on. Seurat did the opposite. He left the colours unmixed, and instead placed tiny separate dots of pure blue and pure yellow right next to each other on the canvas.

Then he let your eyes do the mixing. When you stand far enough back, your eye can no longer see each little dot, so it blends the blue and yellow together for you, and you see green, a green that seems to sparkle and glow more than flat mixed paint ever could. Seurat believed that colours blended by your eye look brighter and more alive than colours muddled together on a palette.

He was so careful about this that a single one of his paintings could take him many months, dot by patient dot. That is the total opposite of Monet, who tried to finish a painting fast before the light changed. Seurat worked slowly, almost like a scientist doing an experiment.

His most famous painting of all, even bigger than the one here, hangs in the city of Chicago in America. It shows crowds of people relaxing in a park on a sunny Sunday, and if you look closely you can even spot a lady walking a pet monkey on a leash. Look back at the *Bathers* here and hunt near the boy's orange hat, where Seurat later added extra tiny dots, still testing his magic even after the painting was done.

The Science Painter and His Friends

Georges Seurat was not just an artist, he was almost a scientist too. He was a quiet, serious, secretive young man who read books about how colours work and how our eyes see them. He learned about a discovery made by a French scientist named Chevreul, who noticed something wonderful. If you place two different colours right next to each other, they can make each other look brighter and more powerful. Put a little orange beside a little blue, and both seem to glow.

Seurat took that idea and built whole paintings out of it, placing thousands of little dots of these partner colours side by side so the whole picture would shimmer. He turned a scientist's discovery into art you can stand in front of and feel.

Seurat was not alone. He had a good friend and follower, another painter named Paul Signac, who loved the dot method too and used even brighter, bolder colours. Together they and a few others became known as the Neo-Impressionists, which means the new Impressionists. They took the Impressionists' love of light and made it into something more careful and more scientific.

Sadly, Seurat's story ends far too soon. He worked in secret, guarding his ideas, and he had only just begun to show the world what he could do when he suddenly fell ill and died at just thirty one years old. His friend Signac carried the dot painting onward for many more years. So when you look at these shimmering dots, remember you are looking at the work of a brilliant young man who saw colour like nobody before him, and who barely had time to show us all he could do.